MAP 2 OF 2 · CHECKED 8 OCTOBER 2026

Choosing a model for the task

Pick the tier before the provider. How complex the task is, what a mistake would cost, how much material the model must read, how fast it has to answer and what it costs at volume decide the tier. Every major provider offers a model at each tier.

FAST AND REPETITIVE — COMPLEX AND HIGH-JUDGMENT

HIGH-VOLUME

Fast

Clear, repeatable tasks with a known right answer.

EVENT AND BUSINESS EXAMPLES

- Classify 5,000 pieces of event feedback by theme
- Extract names, dates and companies from registration forms
- Tag CRM leads by industry and seniority
- Rewrite 200 session headlines to a character limit
- Translate routine attendee emails
- Turn meeting transcripts into action lists

CURRENT MODELS AT THIS TIER

GPT-6 Luna
OpenAI · Released 22 Sep 2026

Claude Haiku 5.5
Anthropic · Released 7 Oct 2026

Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite
Google · Stable since 21 Jul 2026

Brief it: Give it a template and two or three worked examples. Spot-check a sample of the output.

SPEED — COST PER TASK

EVERYDAY

Balanced

Work that needs context and some judgment.

EVENT AND BUSINESS EXAMPLES

- Draft a landing page from a brief
- Summarise a research pack
- Create an agenda and run of show
- Outline a presentation
- Compare three vendor proposals

CURRENT MODELS AT THIS TIER

GPT-6.1 Sol
OpenAI · Released 29 Sep 2026

Claude Sonnet 5.5
Anthropic · Released 28 Sep 2026

Gemini 3.8 Flash
Google · Stable since 2 Sep 2026

Brief it: Give it context, examples and the audience. A person reviews it before it goes out.

SPEED — COST PER TASK

COMPLEX

Deep

Ambiguity, many sources, conflicting constraints or consequential decisions.

EVENT AND BUSINESS EXAMPLES

- Synthesise many sources into a point of view
- Design a multi-track event strategy
- Build a research plan
- Critique a full presentation

CURRENT MODELS AT THIS TIER

GPT-6 Astra
OpenAI · Released 3-4 Sep 2026

Claude Opus 5.5
Anthropic · Released 22 Sep 2026; Claude Fable 5.1 sits above it

Gemini 3.1 Pro or Gemini 3 Deep Think
Google · Deep Think: Google AI Ultra; API in early access

Brief it: Ask for its reasoning, assumptions and evidence. A person makes the final call.

SPEED — COST PER TASK

Five things that move a task along the spectrum

Start in the middle and adjust. Most real tasks mix tiers: a fast model sorts the pile, a deep model writes the judgment.

Complexity
More steps, ambiguity or trade-offs
→ TOWARD DEEP

Risk
A costly or public mistake: go deeper and add human review
→ TOWARD DEEP

Context
Long documents or many sources: add retrieval and a large context window
→ TOWARD DEEP

Speed
Live or real-time use, or thousands of items
← TOWARD FAST

Cost
At volume, small per-task savings add up; test quality first
← TOWARD FAST

Route the task

Ask what the task needs before choosing a model. Some needs are met by adding retrieval, a specialist tool or a supervised workflow, not by a bigger model.

What does the task need?

1 **Repeatable task**
Fast model and a template

2 **Task needs interpretation**
Balanced model with examples and context

3 **Many sources or trade-offs**
Deep model; ask for its reasoning and evidence

4 **Needs current facts**
Add web or document retrieval. Don't rely on the model's memory alone.
10 Web research and deep research
11 Research across your own documents

5 **Needs a media asset**
Route to a specialist image, video, voice or music tool
02 Image generation · 04 Video generation · 06 Voice, speech and dubbing · 07 Music and sound

6 **Needs a real-world action**
Use an authorised workflow or agent, then verify the result
17 Workflow automation and agents

Watch list

- Gemini 4 Argon was announced on 30 September 2026 with access limited to partners. It is not shown until it is generally available.
- Gemini 3.5 Pro was announced at I/O in May 2026 but has not shipped; Gemini 3.1 Pro remains Google's current Pro model.
- OpenAI released GPT-6.1 Sol on 29 September 2026, a week after GPT-6 Sol. It is available in ChatGPT Work, Codex and the API.

Model names change every few weeks. Anthropic names were checked on its own pages; OpenAI and Google names were checked against dated coverage and Google developer documentation. Sources are listed under Sources and notes.